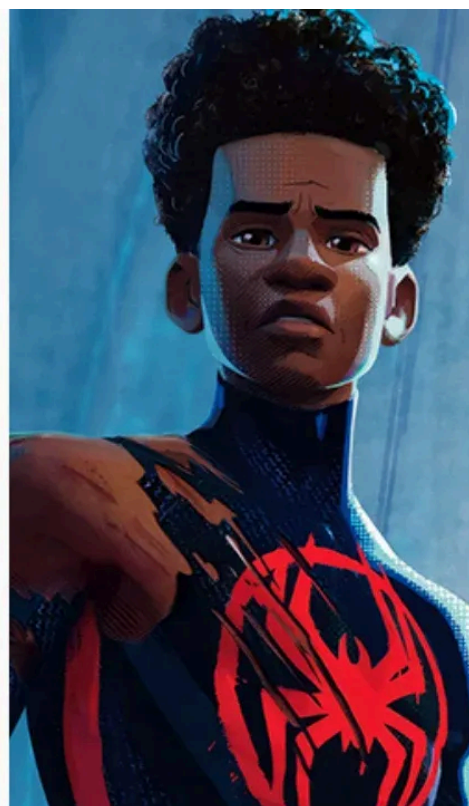


[Blog Post](#)[Plotting & Planning](#)

Save the Cat: A Proven Story Structure to Plot Your Novel With

The Save the Cat beat sheet is a popular story structure that breaks a story into 15 beats, or key moments, that help to ensure you have a clear and compelling beginning, middle, and end.

by [The Campfire Team](#)

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Looking for an easy-to-follow template to ensure your novel is well-paced and

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The Campfire Team

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We're here to help writers imagine, plan, and tell their stories. We started in 2018, and have been working to help you write better stories faster since then. We're thrilled to have you here with us, whether you're just browsing the blog, checking out the community's work in Explore, or creating your own stories in Campfire.

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In this article, we'll explore what the *Save the Cat* [plotting method](#) entails and how to use its story beats to outline your work!



Graphic: Campfire

What is the Save the Cat Method?

The *Save the Cat* plotting method helps writers craft [well-paced stories](#) by **breaking the three-act story structure down into 15 key sections**, also known as beats.

The 15 beats occur in a specific order at a specific place within the narrative, and each beat has key types of events that are associated with it.

Save the Cat isn't just about building a tight plot, though. The *Save the Cat* method also dives into character, theme, and genre.

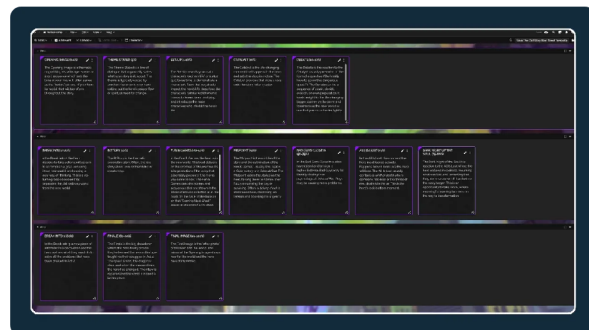
Save the Cat! Writes a Novel opens with a discussion on how to create a story-worthy hero by developing their problem, want, and need—and this holistic approach helps writers develop a story

The History Behind Save the Cat

The *Save the Cat* method began with Hollywood screenwriter Blake Snyder. In an effort to understand what made certain movies more popular than others, Snyder studied hundreds of screenplays and realized that most movies followed a similar narrative structure. They all had fifteen key beats, which always occurred at about the same time within the story.

Snyder gave those plot points fun, memorable names, [whipped up an easy-to-follow template](#), and voilà. The *Save the Cat* plot structure was born.

In 2006, aspiring novelist Jessica Brody used Snyder's screenwriting book to fix a struggling manuscript. The results were so phenomenal that Brody reached out to Snyder to ask his permission to adapt the method for novels. Her 2018 book, *Save the Cat! Writes a Novel*, customizes the beat sheet and story types for novelists.



A *Save the Cat!* template set up using Campfire's Timeline Module, displayed here in the Urban Fantasy theme.

Save the Cat! Beat Sheet

detailed overviews of what happens during each part of their *Save the Cat* novel beat sheet, a successful beat sheet doesn't need to be lengthy.

In fact, Blake Snyder himself encouraged writers to boil each down to a single sentence. According to Snyder, if you're not able to describe your beat in one sentence, you're still unsure about what that beat should be.

Does Save the Cat Work for Novels?

Yes, **the *Save the Cat* plot structure works for novels**. Jessica Brody's book, *Save the Cat! Writes a Novel*, specifically adapts Blake Snyder's original manual for novelists.

In it, Brody discusses how to apply the *Save the Cat* structure to novel-length works and offers hundreds of examples of how *Save the Cat's* genres and beats apply to well-known books.

Save the Cat Story Types

Wondering what should happen at each part of your beat sheet? That's where you'll apply story type. In the *Save the Cat* framework, story type describes the type of transformation your hero will undergo.



Image credits (left to right): *Everything Everywhere All At Once* (A24), *Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness* (Marvel Studios), *Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse* (Sony Pictures).

There are ten *Save the Cat* story types. However, before we get into the types, there are a few things that are important to keep in mind.

First, ***Save the Cat* types are not genres**. They do not focus on the tone of a story (i.e., is it dramatic or comedic?), but rather on the kind of story you're trying to tell. Each of the *Save the Cat* story types could work with different tones, though some tones may work better for certain story types than others.

Similarly, **story types have nothing to do with story setting**. They can occur in any kind of world that you dream up.

The *Save the Cat* types are:

- **Whydunit:** A hero must solve a mystery that reveals something dark about human nature.
- **Rites of Passage:** A hero grapples with the struggles brought about by common challenges like death or loss.
- **Institutionalized:** A hero must escape from a group, like an institution, establishment, or family.

or magical) must come to terms with being destined for greatness.

- **Dude with a Problem:** An average hero finds themselves in extraordinary circumstances.
- **Fool Triumphant:** An underdog hero takes on a powerful establishment.
- **Buddy Love:** A hero meets someone who changes their life (could be a friend, lover, teacher, pet, etc).
- **Out of the Bottle:** An ordinary hero gets temporary magical powers, for instance by being cursed or having their wishes granted.
- **Golden Fleece:** A hero goes on a trip of some kind, searching for something but finding something else.
- **Monster in the House:** A hero must defeat some kind of monster (not necessarily a supernatural one) in an enclosed setting.

When using the *Save the Cat* novel beat sheet to outline your story, you should **consider how your story type affects the kinds of events that might happen** in each of your beats.

For instance, if you're writing a Rites of Passage story, your Catalyst might see your protagonist experiencing an unexpected loss in their life. If you're writing a Superhero story, your Catalyst might involve your hero getting their powers.



Michelle Yeoh as Evelyn Quan Wang in *Everything Everywhere All At Once*. Image

Credit: A24.

Save the Cat Story Type

Examples in Popular Media

- **Rites of Passage:** *Everything Everywhere All At Once*, starring Michelle Yeoh, is arguably a great example of several *Save the Cat!* story types, but perhaps most of all, Rites of Passage. The protagonist, Evelyn, must grapple with divorce, a tax audit of her business, and strained family relationships. Others, however, might say it best reflects the Superhero story type.
- **Dude With a Problem:** Miles Morales, played by Shameik Moore in Marvel's *Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse*, is just a normal teenage guy trying to discover himself until he is bit by a radioactive spider and thrust into a world of heroes and villains that has parallels to his seemingly normal life.
- **Superhero:** Benedict Cumberbatch's Doctor Strange(s) in *Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness* perfectly represents the Superhero story type. It serves up a classic tale of good guys versus bad guys, in which Doctor Strange must save the multiverse

Darkhold) to reunite with her late family.

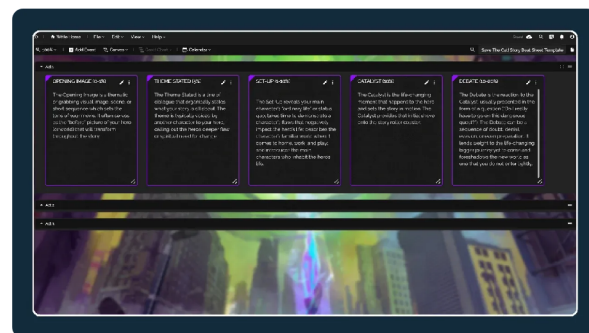
It's possible that **more complex plots can represent multiple *Save the Cat* story types**. For example, some might argue that *Everything Everywhere All At Once* fits the "Superhero" story type and that *Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse* fits "Rites of Passage" or even "Superhero" as well.

Regardless, understanding the conventions of your story type will help you brainstorm the types of events that may happen in your beat sheet.

Save The Cat in the Three Acts

Let's explore the Save the Cat beat sheet in a bit more depth, using Marvel's *Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse* in Campfire's Timeline Module as an example.

For each beat, you'll learn what should happen in it. We've also included where this beat falls in a typical narrative structure in parentheses.



Act I: Exposition

story and understanding who they are (including their problem, want, and need) before their world changes forever.

Beat #1: Opening Image (0-1%)

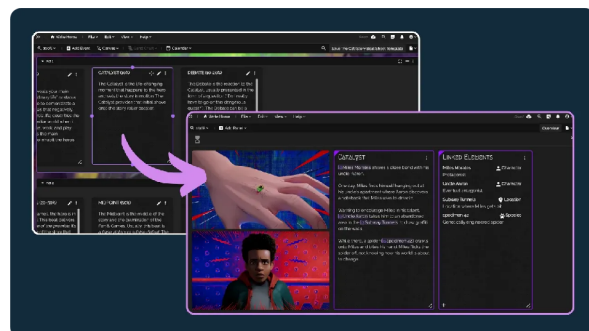
The Opening Image is a “before” snapshot of your hero: who they are and what their world is like. Your reader should immediately get a sense of what your hero is like as a person, as well as what their ordinary world is like before the events of the Catalyst change everything.

Beat #2: Theme Stated (5%)

In the Theme Stated beat, a character (typically not the hero) hints at the life lesson the hero must learn or discover to complete their arc. Remember, *Save the Cat* isn't just about creating a tight plot: it's also about crafting an emotionally satisfying story where the main character undergoes a profound transformation. During this beat, you foreshadow what that change might be.

Beat #3: Setup (1-10%)

The Setup explores the hero's present circumstances, establishing their primary goal or goals, and introducing support characters. This section is important because it helps flesh out the main character and their world.



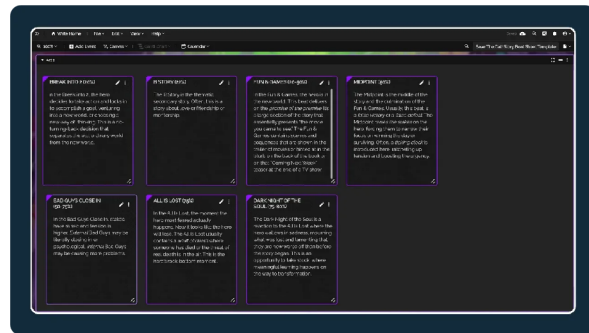
biting Miles Morales on the hand while he and his uncle are drawing graffiti in a subway tunnel.

Beat #4: Catalyst (10%)

Often known in other plotting methods as the inciting incident, the Catalyst is what catapults the hero into their new world (or way of thinking). This event forever changes the hero—they cannot go back to their old way of living.

Beat #5: Debate (10-20%)

In the Debate beat, the hero expresses reluctance to take the action required by the Catalyst. This beat is all about asking questions. The hero might wonder things like, “Should I do this?” or “Can I do this?” or “Is this right for me?”



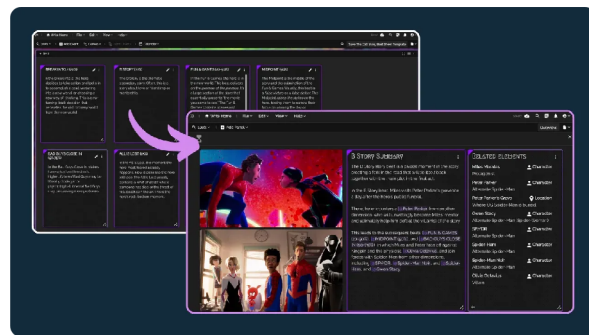
Act II: New World

The second act of the *Save the Cat* structure is the longest. We see the hero in their new world, experiencing all the challenges and triumphs that come with it. During this section, we'll often meet new characters and learn more about how the hero's flaws are holding them back.

The hero takes action. They leave their old world or way of thinking behind and forever enter a new state.

Beat #7: B Story (22%)

The B Story introduces a subplot, typically in the form of a new character that will help the hero learn their ultimate lesson. The B Story character is often a love interest, mentor, friend, or nemesis.



The B Story beat in *Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse* sets off an important chain of events that will ultimately serve the story's greater plot.

Beat #8: Fun and Games (20-50%)

The Fun and Games beat is the longest beat in the entire novel. We follow the hero through a series of ups and downs, challenges and successes, as they explore their new world or way of thinking.

This beat isn't necessarily about having fun, though some protagonists might. What specifically happens will depend on your story type and the transformation your hero needs to undergo. Typically, during the Fun and Games section, heroes are either on an upward path (experiencing a general trend toward success) or a downward path (experiencing a general trend toward struggle and failure).

The Fun and Games section of your story leads to a pivotal moment: the Midpoint. At this beat, the hero experiences a False Victory or False Defeat that raises the stakes and pushes them toward their key transformation.

If your hero experiences a False Victory, they might be lulled into thinking that their problems are fixed and they won't experience any more struggles. If they experience a False Defeat, they might worry that they are doomed to failure.

Either way, the hero is wrong: there's still a lot of story left!

Beat #10: Bad Guys Close In (50-75%)

After the Midpoint, events start escalating for the hero. Their flaws are starting to catch up to them and they learn quickly that the False Victory or Defeat they experienced was indeed false.

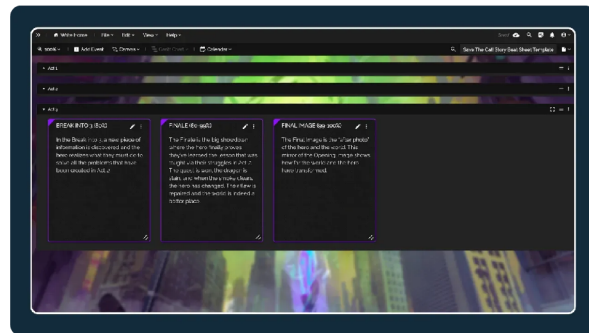
Your hero hasn't truly changed yet and so they will continue to struggle until they learn their lesson and complete their transformation.

Beat #11: All is Lost (75%)

All is Lost is the lowest point of the novel, where the hero hits rock bottom. Their flaws have caught up to them and something has happened to push them to their breaking point.

It's important that the All is Lost moment is in some way caused by the hero: whether by their choices or actions, this terrible experience will force the hero to reflect and make a change moving forward.

Defeated, the hero processes everything that's happened to them thus far. In this beat, the hero wallows in the aftermath of the All is Lost beat, wondering how their life has ended up this badly and what they can possibly do to turn things around. The hero typically has an epiphany that their circumstances are a result of their own actions or beliefs.

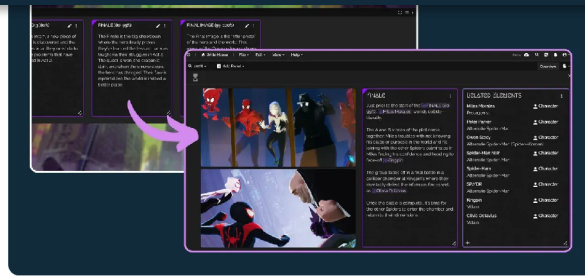


Act III: Transformation

Fortunately for your hero, the story doesn't end when all is lost. In Act III, your hero will figure out a way to right their wrongs and complete their transformation.

Beat #13: Break Into Three (80%)

Good news for your hero. All isn't lost! In this beat, the hero has an a-ha moment and realizes what they must do to fix their problems. They begin to put a plan in place to fix what's been broken.



The Finale of *Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse* shows an explosive fight between the protagonists (the Spiders) and the antagonists, Kingpin and Doc Ock.

Beat #14: The Finale (80-99%)

During the Finale, the hero successfully develops and enacts a plan to fix their problems, thereby resolving the main conflict of the story. This beat gives your hero a chance to prove that they have learned the lessons of Act III and can change for the better.

Beat #15: Finale Image (99-100%)

We get a final snapshot of the hero, forever changed by their journey, to contrast where they were in the Opening Image. This beat should parallel the Opening Image and show both the hero and the readers how far your main character has come.

Will the Beat Sheet Work For You?

The *Save the Cat* beat sheet will work for you if you're looking for a **highly structured and detailed way to outline your novel** that focuses primarily on plot and character arc.

and worldbuilding, then you might not want to use *Save the Cat* when planning or evaluating your work.



Benedict Cumberbatch as the eponymous Doctor Strange and Elizabeth Olson as Wanda Maximoff (aka the Scarlet Witch) face off in a classic battle of good versus evil in *Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness*. Image credit: Marvel Studios.

For some writers, the *Save the Cat* beat sheet is **too formulaic**. Critics have bemoaned that this structure results in books and movies that feel overly similar and don't take any risks.

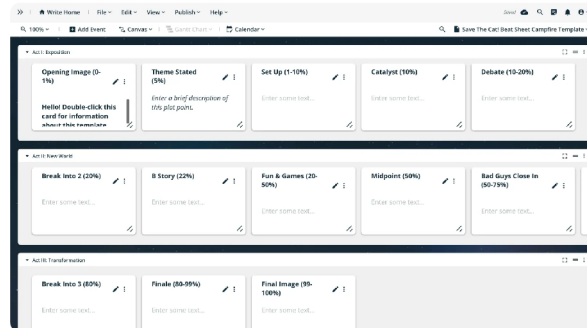
This can be said of just about any superhero movie. We always know how the story is going to end—with the hero triumphant and the villain defeated—regardless of how many books or movies it takes to tell the story.

Others say that **this method leaves out key points**, like worldbuilding, that are extremely consequential for drafting an effective story.

Ultimately, it's up to you to decide whether or not the *Save the Cat* plot structure contains the key information and exercises you need to draft your novel.

Plotting Method for Yourself

For many writers (including me), *Save the Cat* has provided an effective, easy-to-follow structure to understand and develop a strong story.



Fifteen Beat Story Structure Template

Find a **template for *Save the Cat*'s fifteen-beat story structure** in Campfire's Timeline Module.

To load a template in your project, click the **View** tab while in the Timeline Module, select "Manage Templates," then select from the options available or save your own!

Templates are editable, so once you load it, make it your own!

New to Campfire? It's free to sign up for, no credit card required. Create your account, load your new template that's

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If you're looking for a way to ensure your novel contains the key moments necessary to create an emotional resonance for your readers, you may want to give *Save the Cat* a try.

4 Comments

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JD Random " I just tried the template code and it's no longer good. Is there a new code?..."

**The Campfire Team** 6 months ago

Hey JD! The code above (3JAH5N) should still work. Make sure you're uploading the template to the Timeline itself (so, from the canvas view vs. an event element). Let me know if that helps! –Amanda

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